People Like Me

Don’t switch careers alone

Matching career switchers with a Career Guide who has made the same move, and a small pod making it with them.

Product case study · Discovery to go-to-market

THE PROBLEM

Plenty of people. None like them.

Career switchers can't reach people who have already made the same move. Without them, they don't know where to start, lose motivation through weeks of rejection, and give up before they switch.

12 of 13

couldn't find people in their field going through the same thing, or someone senior

11 of 13

struggled most with staying motivated (8) or reaching the right people (8)

6 of 8

switchers didn't know where to start; 0 of 5 long job hunters said so

11 of 13

already spent money on support during that period

Source: 4 face-to-face interviews and 13 survey responses · 2

DISCOVERY

We set out to learn, not to validate

4

Face-to-face interviews

People who had left a job, taken a break or were planning a switch

13

Survey responses

5 switching, 3 on a break, 5 in a long job search; 10 of 13 with 7 to 12 years' experience

What changed our thinking

Not loneliness

Only 2 of 13 felt alone. The pain is momentum and access.

Not a crowd

Large groups go quiet. People want someone ahead (8 of 13 chose experts) and peers beside them (8 of 13).

Not one-off help

Courses and expert calls give direction, but nothing keeps people going week to week.

Nobody in either sample had been laid off, so we focused on career switchers · 3

USER PERSONA

Meghna, the stalled switcher

Knows she wants to change direction; can't find anyone who made the same move from where she stands.

Situation

- 8 years in sales at a large company
- Left a year ago; wants to move into product
- Lives in Pune, has a home loan

Goals

- Know where to start
- Keep preparing steadily
- Land a role that fits

Behaviours

- Relies on job boards and her own network
- Bought a course, spoke to experts
- Prepares in bursts, then loses the rhythm

Frustrations

- Plenty of people, none in her phase
- Weeks of no replies wear her down
- Her network ran dry after a few asks

A composite of the four interviews and the survey · 4

ROOT CAUSE TO SOLUTION

Five whys led to a three-layer stack

1	They give up: no starting point, and momentum fades
2	Momentum fades because nobody holds them to it
3	The people they find aren't in their situation, and help is one-off
4	People who made the move have no easy, safe way to help
5	**Root cause:** platforms know people by job title, not by the move they made

TOP · fixes 1 and 2

Accountability loop

Weekly goals the Career Guide and pod see; a real person reaches out on a slip

MIDDLE · fixes 2, 3 and 4

Career Guide and pod

Guide weekly, pod twice a week, for eight weeks

FOUNDATION · fixes 5

Move-based matching

Built from each person's own story and CV

PRIORITISATION

Twelve ideas, five shortlisted, scored with RICE

Idea	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	Score
Career Guide, weekly	3	3	3	2	13.5
Situation pods, twice a week	3	3	2	2	9.0
Occasional expert sessions	3	2	2	2	6.0
Weekly goals tracker on its own	3	1	2	1	6.0
Move-based matching on its own	3	1	2	2	3.0

The Career Guide leads; pods come second. Together they form the product, with matching as the engine and goals as the accountability layer. Expert sessions join later, for questions pods share.

Score = Reach × Impact × Confidence ÷ Effort, each 1 to 3·6

USER STORY

Meghna’s eight weeks

As a career switcher, I want a guide who made my move and people making it with me, so I know where to start and keep going until I land.

BEFORE

Stuck for months

Bought a course, messaged strangers, lost momentum after rejections.

DAY 1

Tells her story

Signs in, picks her objective, shares her story and CV, confirms her profile.

DAY 2

Chooses her Career Guide

Picks Arjun, who left FMCG sales for product, and joins a pod of five.

WEEK 1

Gets a real plan

Arjun turns the app’s draft into five milestones; she sets three goals.

WEEK 3

Slips, and is noticed

Two rejections, no update. Arjun messages her; her pod cheers her next win.

WEEK 8

Interview-ready

Portfolio done, warm conversations, interviews lined up.

WHAT WE BUILT

A live web app, from sign-in to Week 1

Story-based onboarding

Optional prompts by voice or text, plus a CV. AI drafts a profile the user confirms.

Career Guide matching

3 to 5 approved guides, each with a reason and rating. “Adjust what matters” refreshes the set.

A plan the guide owns

AI drafts 4 to 6 milestones; the Career Guide finalises them in the first conversation.

Pods and rhythm

4 to 6 people at the same stage. Guide weekly, pod twice a week, with calendar invites.

Weekly accountability

Two or three goals a week, seen by guide and pod. A person reaches out on a slip.

Trust and privacy

Guides verified and approved by a person. No contact details shared without consent.

Built with React and TypeScript, Supabase, a Node server and the Gemini API, deployed from GitHub to Render.

Admin access was added later in the build, so the admin view shows sign-ins from that point on; earlier test sign-ins aren’t captured.

EARLY FEEDBACK

What early testers told us, and what we changed

Tester	Where they got stuck	What they valued	What we're changing
Charu	Onboarding felt long: too many open story questions	A smooth flow and a clear journey	Reduced and merged the questions. Next: options and example text
Astha	Couldn't see pod members' profiles; the weekly calendar wasn't clear	A smooth journey through the app	Simpler interface, guiding instructions, pod members' profiles
Arjun	After sign-in, he landed on the full 8-week plan, not his own progress	The way the weekly plan is laid out	Redefining the dashboard around his progress
Karthik	Once matched, he couldn't tell why this Career Guide and pod were right for him	The pod idea	A "Why this match" panel for the Career Guide and the pod

From walkthroughs of the live app · 9

LAUNCH PLAN

Pilot first, then launch, then scale

STEP 1 · PILOT, 1 MONTH

Prove demand by hand

- Hand-pick credible Career Guides and experts
- One registration form across LinkedIn, Reddit, course cohorts, WhatsApp, freelancing communities and job platforms
- Hand-matched pods led by those guides
- Test free versus a small fee

STEP 2 · SMALL LAUNCH

Open to a small group

- Change or pivot the app from pilot results
- Founder-led LinkedIn with real pilot stories
- Alumni networks, starting with the founder's colleges
- Graduates invited to become Career Guides

STEP 3 · SCALE

Segments and revenue

- Mothers returning to work, veterans, people moving back to India
- Paid Career Guide sessions and guided pods
- Employers hiring switchers who opt in

Pilot measures: sign-ups, weekly attendance, goals met, interviews landed, and how many would pay.

LAUNCH PLAN · STEP 1 OF 3 · MONTH 1

Pilot: prove the demand by hand

What we'll do

1. Recruit 5 to 8 credible Career Guides and experts through personal outreach, each with a short conversation with the founder
2. Publish one registration form, shared on LinkedIn, Reddit, course cohorts, WhatsApp communities, freelancing communities (Fiverr, Upwork), Slack and Discord career groups, and job platforms
3. Screen registrations and hand-match people into pods of 4 to 6, each led by a Career Guide
4. Run four weeks inside the app: guide weekly, pod twice a week, weekly goals
5. Make half the pods free and charge the others a small fee of [₹__]
6. Interview a few participants each week about what helps and what doesn't

Goal

Prove that switchers sign up, keep showing up, and value it enough to pay.

What we measure

Registrations, share who join a pod, weekly attendance, goals met, interviews landed, willingness to pay, and guides who stay.

Move on when

Most pod members attend through week 4 and some pay: [thresholds to set before the pilot].

LAUNCH PLAN · STEP 2 OF 3 · MONTHS 2 TO 4

Small launch: open the app to a small group

What we'll do

1. Change the app, or pivot, based on what the pilot showed
2. Open sign-ups through a waitlist, keeping about two switchers per Career Guide
3. Post founder-led LinkedIn stories from the pilot every week
4. Reach alumni networks, starting with the founder's undergraduate and master's colleges
5. Partner with career courses and cohorts to offer pods to their learners
6. Grow through referrals and invite graduates to become Career Guides

Goal

Reach the first [__] switchers through the app, and prove they stay without hand-holding.

What we measure

Activation, requests accepted within 48 hours, attendance, goals done, week-4 retention, interviews and offers, and referrals per user.

Move on when

Week-4 retention and outcomes hold at pilot levels with the app alone: [targets to set after the pilot].

LAUNCH PLAN · STEP 3 OF 3 · MONTH 5 ONWARDS

Scale: new segments and revenue

What we'll do

1. Add one segment at a time, each with its own adjusted rhythm: mothers returning to work, armed forces veterans, people moving back to India, freelancers and founders returning to corporate jobs
2. Introduce paid Career Guide sessions and guided pods
3. Partner with employers to hire job-ready switchers who opt in
4. Work with returnship and veteran resettlement programmes
5. Keep guide quality high: ratings after every conversation, automatic pause below a threshold, regular reviews

Goal

Turn a proven program into a sustainable business across more career moves.

What we measure

Paying users, retention by segment, hires through partners, revenue per switcher, and guide supply against demand.

Move on when

Each new segment matches the first segment's retention before the next one opens.

GO-TO-MARKET

Who, how we reach them, and what we track

First customer
Mid-career switchers, about 7 to 12 years in

The promise
A guide who's been there, a pod beside you, a weekly rhythm

Both sides
Recruit Career Guides before switchers, and keep recruiting

Channels

- Founder-led LinkedIn content
- Career-switcher communities and course cohorts
- Freelancing communities like Fiverr and Upwork
- Alumni groups and college networks
- Referrals: "Invite someone making your move"

What we track

- Activation: profile done, guide requested
- Matching: requests accepted within 48 hours
- Engagement: attendance and goals done
- Retention at week 4, outcomes, referrals

Go or no-go after the pilot: [thresholds to be set before the pilot]

GO-TO-MARKET PLAYBOOK

Six steps to the first committed users

1. Sharpen the message

“A Career Guide who’s been there, and a pod beside you.” Test headlines in pilot posts and keep the one that converts.

2. Build guide supply first

Hand-pick and approve Career Guides from alumni, course graduates and personal networks before inviting switchers.

3. Give value in communities

Share real switch stories and host short Q&A sessions with Career Guides, rather than posting ads.

4. Partner where switchers gather

Career courses, alumni associations, freelancer platforms’ communities and returnship programmes.

5. Test pricing early

Free pods against a small fee in the pilot; later, paid Career Guide sessions and guided pods.

6. Turn graduates into growth

Graduates share their stories, invite people making the same move, and become Career Guides.

Every week: check which channel brings switchers who stay, and put more effort there.